Musical theatre essay for the Department of Drama, Theatre and Dance

This is an essay assignment of 2,500 words for a second year Drama module on 'The Idea of the Musical'. Students can choose from a list of eight set questions to answer. For first class work, markers are looking for excellence in these areas:

- Understanding the question
- Use of course materials
- Secondary reading
- Argument
- Structure and style
- Grammar and referencing

MARKER'S COMMENTS

How did you do?

This is one of the best essays by a student that I've ever read. It's brilliant. It draws on an excellent range of very sophisticated writings on the musical and sexuality. DA Miller's book on the musical – (*Place for Us: Essay on the Broadway Musical*. Cambridge, Mass: Harvard University Press, 1998) is a wonderful book, but, in its mixture of queer autobiography and post-structuralist theory, is really not for the faint-hearted; you also draw on important – but notoriously difficult – queer theorists like Eve Sedgwick and Judith Butler and you handle them deftly with precision and elegance. I also appreciate the independence of your research, turning up wonderful things like the Christopher Gittings essay, which I have to admit I'd never read but will now!

Throughout, you are really alert to the subtlety of these debates, the nature of representation before the Stonewall riots of 1969, that are held to mark the start of an era of 'gay liberation'. You are particularly articulate on the use of 'queer coding', where something in a musical (a character, a story, a song) might appear to be resolutely heterosexual but, when looked at differently, can be seen to be expressing something quite different, something subversive, something queer. You elaborate a very strong argument for how this might form the basis for re-reading the musical and its conventions. This is particularly impressive because, living in the twenty-first century, it can be difficult to understand and empathise with a very different generation and era in which non-mainstream sexualities had a very different cultural position and necessarily expressed itself in very different ways; it shows, therefore, both a smart and constructive use of secondary research and an empathetic intelligence that brings those insights together. I think it shows admirable confidence to take issue with a musical theatre scholar as well-known and celebrated as Stacy Wolf for what you persuasively suggest is an insufficient acknowledgment of that earlier era's use of queer coding.

It's also written beautifully, with great elegance and sophistication. I seriously hope you are thinking of an academic career because you're clearly ready for it.

CONTINUED BELOW

The standard rubric that we use for this mark in the Department of Drama, Theatre & Dance (which I very rarely get to use) is as follows:

This shows a very serious engagement with the question and is an original contribution to existing scholarship and makes a valuable intervention in those debates. It demonstrates precise and subtle understanding throughout. It shows deep insight in its rigorous engagement with research and has a persuasive and complex methodology supporting it. Its argument is philosophically subtle and complex, written and structured with consistent sophistication and authority.

That's a description I'd be pleased to receive of something I'd written and I'm delighted to be able to apply it to your work.

How can you do better?

Well, let's be honest, you can't easily! There are only two more stepped marks above the mark I've given you. For a relatively short essay in a 15-credit module, I think you're writing about as well as anyone should reasonably expect.

But I suppose there is always greater depth and thinking and research. I guess it could be interesting to complete the circle, in a sense, and look at queer coding and its contemporary value. You will remember that we talked in class about 'Let It Go' from *Frozen*, a song from 2013, way past the era where LBGTQ+ people were mostly forced to hide their sexuality. It's a song that appears to be Elsa expressing the relief at being able to express her magical ability to control ice and snow, yet it has become a queer anthem (and was even accused, by an eccentric radio DJ, of being part of a secret plot by Disney to indoctrinate young girls into lesbianism!). It might be interesting to speculate why, in a world where – with exceptions and problems, of course – it is far more possible to be open about one's dissident sexuality than it was in, say, the 1950s, LGBTQ+ people are still drawn to the ambiguities and double meanings of queer coding in the musical.

But what can I say? This is so rewarding to read. It's wonderful.

In the classic musical, gay men and lesbians rarely feature explicitly as characters and yet these musicals have often had a strong fan base in the LGBTQ+ community. Why might this be the case?

CeDAS comments

Queer audiences have always been drawn to both classic and contemporary musical theatre. Particularly in the years preceding the Stonewall Riots, musicals rarely featured explicitly queer characters, even though many of the creatives who developed them were queer themselves. However, these 'Golden Age' musicals commonly employ 'queer coding' – a character is subliminally given traits *associated* with being queer, without explicitly stating that they *are*. As such, queer audiences can identify with these characters without either one – character or audience member – being 'outed' as LGBTQ+. To further

extremes, musicals dramatise and exaggerate the social norms of gender and sexuality, to such a degree that these norms seem absurd. As heteronormative narratives are rendered unrealistic, musical theatre challenges heteronormativity itself; therefore, the musical is an inherently queer entity. For the sake of convenience, I will use the terms 'queer' and 'gay/lesbian' interchangeably, as 'queer' is the more modern, catch-all term. Additionally, 'queerness', a word which itself defies definition, feels more apt to describe the versatile and uncategorisable medium of musical theatre.

This introduction swiftly establishes the topic of the essay, sets up the key thesis and then provides a useful definition of terms.

The classic musical and its 'Golden Age' pre-date the 1969 Stonewall riots – considered a crucial turning point in LGBTQ+ history, rights, and representation, particularly in the USA. The years surrounding Stonewall have "deeply influenced mainstream culture in many ways" and were "crucial to the development of modern LGBTQ+ identity, culture, and legal status"; the riots mark the progression from a period of "social and legal persecution against LGBTQ+ people" to the possibility of equal rights[1]. The 'Golden Age' of musical theatre was coeval with the pre-Stonewall era of queer persecution, so could not feature openly queer characters. Since these classic musicals were marketed towards an intolerant demographic, they could only offer subtle hints towards queerness, known as 'coding'. However, there is an argument to be made that the musical exaggerates heteronormative values, to the point of excess, making it inherently queer. Both classic and contemporary musicals create a 'queering' effect, where sexuality and gender are seen to be performative – both onstage and off.

An informative backdrop to the 'Golden Age' musical and how social disapproval of queer characters lead to 'coding'.

One possible explanation for the musical's queer following is its subtle dealings with the non-normative. Throughout the era of the 'Golden Age'/classic musical, queer representation was unheard of, due to widespread intolerance within this period. For this reason, Elizabeth Freeman suggests that "gays and lesbians have been figured as having no past… and, crucially, no history as a distinct people", such is the absence of queer representation[2]. The culmination of this erasure, she argues, is that "sexual dissidents have had to understand what is prior to our own lives with whatever heuristic is at hand: conjecture, fantasy, overreading, revision, a seemingly myopic focus on ephemera"[3]. Her concept of 'overreading,' wherein LGBTQ+ individuals, seeking representation, will interpret fictional characters as queer with minimal evidence, is particularly relevant. Emerging from this concept is the notion of 'queer coding' – attributing queer traits to a character, without explicit confirmation of their queerness. Coding is defined as "the adoption of a system of signals… that protect the creator from the dangerous consequences of directly stating particular messages" and is not only open

This excellent analysis deftly supported by a source (Freeman) goes much deeper to look at how LGBTQ+ audiences may look for coded representation even when it may not have been intended.

[1] Sean Heather K. McGraw, *The Gay Liberation Movement: Before and after Stonewall* (New York: Rosen Publishing Group, 2018) p.8.
[2] Elizabeth Freeman, 'Introduction', *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies*, 13.2 (2007), p.162.
[3] Freeman, p.162.

to interpretation but can be achieved unintentionally by the creator[4]. Therefore, according to these ideas, LGBTQ+ audience members, conscious of their own persecution, can interpret subtle references and allusions as 'coding' to find representation when there is none explicitly there.

Examples of queer coding are widespread throughout media, as queer characters are neglected in favour of a heteronormative demographic. One such example occurs in the classic film and musical, *The Wizard of Oz*: in the song 'If I Only Had the Nerve', the Cowardly Lion sings "I'm just a dandy-lion", accentuating the word 'dandy' with a 'limp wrist' hand flick[5]. This gesture, considered to be "extravagantly effeminate"[6], subliminally codes the Lion as having queer characteristics – effeminacy is associated with gay men. Moreover, the Lion is repeatedly described as a "sissy"[7], defined as "A boy or man whose behaviour, demeanour, or appearance is considered in some way to be effeminate or lacking in manliness, esp. one regarded as feeble, cowardly, timid"[8]. Here, the ideas of effeminacy and cowardice come together – the Lion is considered not brave enough to be a 'proper' lion, as he is too "dandy", just like stereotypical views of gay men as 'unmanly'. Here, it becomes possible to read the Cowardly Lion as an allegory for queerness, even though he has no love interest, let alone a male one. Whilst I am referencing the film adaptation of *The Wizard of Oz*, the film reflects the essential ideas of the stage musical. The same goes for any future references to other film adaptations of musicals – I will be using these as evidence of the ideas built into the libretto and stagecraft of their original source material.

A useful justification for analysing film adaptations. Perhaps this might sit better towards the top of the paragraph rather than here where it feels like an afterword.

Other instances of queer coding within musical theatre include *Calamity Jane*, which characterises Jane, or 'Calam', as a crossdresser. She both looks and behaves masculinely, much like a stereotypical butch lesbian. Additionally, the song 'A Woman's Touch' features the two female leads, Jane and Katie, redecorating Jane's cabin to be more homely, becoming "a shiny castle built for two//Me and you" [9]. There is clear queer imagery here – the pair are in a domestic setting, as if they could live together in a loving homosocial relationship. 'Homosocial' is defined as "[describing] social bonds between persons of the same sex; it is a neologism, obviously formed by analogy with "homosexual", and just as

As with the discussion of the Cowardly Lion in The Wizard of Oz, this analysis of friendship in Calamity Jane and Chicago delivers useful perspectives on coding, all supported by sources.

[4] Joan N. Radner and Susan S. Lanser, 'The Feminist Voice: Strategies of Coding in Folklore and Literature', *The Journal of American Folklore*, 100.398 (1987), 412–25 <https://doi.org/10.2307/540901>, p.414.
[5] *The Wizard of Oz*, dir. by Victor Fleming (Loews Cineplex Entertainment, 1939).
[6] Jonathon Green, 'Limp Wrist', in *Green's Dictionary of Slang* (Chambers Harrap Publishers, 2011).
[7] *The Wizard of Oz*.
[8] 'Sissy, n. and Adj.', *OED Online* (Oxford University Press) <https://www.oed.com/view/Entry/180429> [accessed 9 December 2022].
[9] *Calamity Jane*, dir. by David Butler (Warner Bros., 1953).

obviously meant to be distinguished from "homosexual""[10]. It is, therefore, not quite a romantic relationship emerging between these female characters, and they both have male love interests, leading the musical to a heteronormative resolution. Nonetheless, there is something 'queer' within it – Jane and Katie are of the same gender, and their close relationship is slightly suggestive of implicit romance. Similar instances of homosocial relations occur in other classic musicals: Grantaire and Enjolras from *Les Misérables*, and Roxie and Velma from *Chicago*. Both these examples develop close friendships with one another, to the extent that they can be considered 'homosocial', and modern-day audiences 'ship' them together. These instances of coding share a level of deniability – it is impossible to claim that these characters are definitely queer, but there are always hints at possible queer meanings within them.

Queer coding is instantiated within the contemporary musical *Wicked*, where the narrative centres around the friendship between the two female principal characters – Elphaba and Glinda – in a homosocial way. Just like in *Calamity Jane*, a male love interest is introduced to offset the musical's queer coding, yet the plot hinges on the relationship between the female characters, with Fiyero as a subplot. *Wicked* begins with Elphaba and Glinda as sworn rivals, following their journey to friends, then enemies again, and the show finds its resolution in their reunion, all the while claiming that they are heterosexual.

However, *Wicked* has also been critically received as a queer creation itself, rather than merely 'coding'. The 2003 megamusical is undoubtedly post-Golden Age and post-Stonewall, yet it employs numerous techniques of the classic musical, albeit in 'queer' ways. **Stacy Wolf posits** that *Wicked*'s stagecraft, score, and libretto (particularly the multiple duets between Elphaba and Glinda) construct the two female protagonists as a "queer couple"[11]. **Wolf first evidences** the show's first duet: 'What Is This Feeling?', a "hate song" evocative of 'People Will Say We're in Love' from *Oklahoma!* (1943) and 'I'll Know' from *Guys and Dolls* (1950)[12]. These two classic musical duets present the heterosexual romantic leads as diametrically opposed, to the degree that they disgust one another, whilst the audience can see the chemistry and inevitable romance between them. *Wicked* both mirrors and problematises this effect, as it sets up the same opposition between Elphaba and Glinda – Glinda is established as girlish and vacuous, whilst Elphaba is considered grotesque and has a strong sense of justice. Additionally, **Wolf argues**, lyrics such as "my face is flushing" are evocative of a romantic crush, creating a "doubly queer" effect – it appears to be a song of both love and

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[10] Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, 'Introduction', in *Between Men: English Literature and Male Homosocial Desire* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2015), p.1.
[11] Stacy Ellen Wolf, '"Changed for the Better": Queer Conventions in Wicked (2003)', in *Changed for Good: A Feminist History of the Broadway Musical* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2011), p. 202.
[12] Wolf, pp.197-8.

hate, between two women[13]. Through multiple traditional musical techniques, "*Wicked* signals that it will follow the conventions of mid-twentieth-century musical, but queerly, with two women as the musical's couple"[14], as **Wolf attests**. Whilst Fiyero is introduced as a heteronormative love interest for both Elphaba and Glinda, Wolf regards this as superficial – he is denied the depth of character, and the stage time, granted to the women – since the plot hinges on their relationship with each other, not with him[15]. He is introduced halfway through Act One, and only has one duet with Elphaba, as opposed to Glinda's four. **According to Wolf's argument**, and the libretto of the musical, Fiyero is irrelevant in comparison to *Wicked*'s female leads – the complexity of Elphaba and Glinda's relationship is always the musical's focal point, and there is an inevitable queer reading to this end.

Additionally, beyond traditional understandings of 'queerness' as simply relating to sexuality, contemporary queer theorists consider 'queer' as a verb: to "[represent] a mode of critical resistance against conceptual closure and normativity, offering alternatives to norms, stable and universal identities, regimes of the normal and of common sense"[16]. *Wicked* not only "offers alternatives" to musical theatre "norms" – conventions established by the classic musical – but 'queers' the infamous, well-known tale of *The Wizard of Oz*. *Wicked*, then, is an inherently queer creation, ratifying Wolf's claims.

However, Wolf's argument has a critical fallacy - its implications for the classic musical. If *Wicked* appropriates and 'queers' musical theatre conventions, then the classic musical must always be normative, with no queer meanings, hidden or otherwise. This is disproven by the aforementioned queer coding within these musicals. Moreover, there is a conflicting argument to be made: **the musical dramatises heteronormativity to the point of excess, hence becoming unrealistic. By extension, the musical itself is a queer entity.**

A primary facet of contemporary queer theory is the idea that sexuality and gender are oppressive social constructs, and, consequently, performative aspects of identity. Judith Butler describes these constructs as "fictive phenomena that gain power within discourse"[17]. In essence, gender and sexuality are imaginary concepts, yet they have immense power because society makes them real – just like in theatre, the imaginary becomes true. As a result, Butler claims that "gender is a performance with clearly punitive consequences" and that partaking in this performance is "a

The highlighted paragraphs follow a highly effective sequence of argumentative moves:

1. Provide a clear account of a scholar's position with neutral reporting verbs and phrases (posits, evidences, attests, according to).

2. Challenge that position: 'However, Wolf's argument has a critical fallacy…'

See Rusty's other essay in *First Ink* for a further example of critical stance to a scholarly source.

Unconvinced by Wolf, the writer now proceeds to lay down an alternative argument. The rest of the essay builds this argument.

[13] Ibid.
[14] Wolf, p.198.
[15] Ibid., p.215.
[16] Nick Rumens, Eloisio Moulin de Souza, and Jo Brewis, 'Queering Queer Theory in Management and Organization Studies: Notes toward Queering Heterosexuality', *Organization Studies*, 40.4 (2019), p.598.
[17] Judith Butler, *Gender Trouble: Tenth Anniversary Edition* (London: Routledge, 2002), p.152.

strategy of survival"[18]. The notion of identity as performance would resonate with a closeted queer audience, and it becomes possible to reverse this idea – if queer identity is performance, then performance must reflect queer identity. Along these lines, Raymond Knapp argues that "musicals provide materials for *performance*, material that may be performed not only by the cast of the show but also, eventually, by those in the audience… Gender roles and sexuality are, above all, *performed* attributes of personal identity and so constitute a central dimension of how people are defined, both onstage and off"[19]. Though the heteronormative endings within classic musicals may appear to counteract their queer codings, Knapp proposes that these endings are deliberately performative. The characters, like the audience members, are pigeonholed into designated, 'performed' heteronormative roles. **From these ideas, another explanation for why musicals resonate with queer people emerges: a queer audience, who had to 'perform' their conformity to gender roles and heteronormativity in order to be accepted, would recognise the same experience when it is put on stage.**

The highlighted text explores performativity closely. A chunky quote from Knapp is used expertly to build a strong insight in the final sentence.

Knapp's thoughts progress, however, to propose that musical theatre exaggerates heteronormativity, portraying it as abnormal: "Nearly always in stage portrayals, and especially in musicals, exaggeration is central to how [characters] are presented, especially regarding gender and sexuality"[20]. Thus, the normativity demonstrated by the musical is overplayed to highlight its performative nature. One example of this occurs in the much-beloved 'Greased Lightnin'' sequence from *Grease* (film 1978, originally written 1971), which creates a visually spectacular display of hyper-masculinity. It exclusively features teenage boys as its central characters, misogynistic lyrics such as "she's a real pussy wagon", and choreography characterised by 'masculine' hip thrusts[21]. Regardless, the all-male, macho sequence cannot be described as anything other than camp. The heightened, melodramatic assertion of masculinity removes feminine sexuality entirely, creating implicit homosexual undertones. As such, the masculinity within 'Greased Lightnin'' is so excessive that it cannot be taken seriously as heteronormative at all. Christopher Gittings reinforces this argument, stating that "the structures of the Hollywood musical are relocated in a field of irony so as to enable the singing and dancing performances to be those of queer nation"[22]. In other words, heteronormativity and gender roles are performed 'ironically', heightened so that they become queer.

This paragraph offers a good example of how a writer can lend clarity to something quite conceptual, even abstruse through discussion of a telling example. We move from Judith Butler and Raymond Knapp to Greased Lightning – and, in so doing, much light is shed on ideas about excess and heteronormativity.

A similar effect is created throughout *West Side Story* (1957), famed for its male dancers as they play New York gang members. These classically

[18] Butler, p.178.
[19] Raymond Knapp, 'Gender and Sexuality', in *The American Musical and the Performance of Personal Identity* (Oxford: Princeton University Press, 2009), p. 205.
[20] Knapp, p.206.
[21] *Grease*, dir. by Randal Kleiser (Paramount Pictures, 1978).
[22] Christopher Gittings, 'Zero Patience, Genre, Difference, and Ideology: Singing and Dancing Queer Nation', *Cinema Journal*, 41.1 (2001), p.31.

trained dancers must portray the pinnacle of masculinity, yet there is a common stereotype that male dancers are gay, and therefore effeminate. The musical portrays gang violence exclusively through dance, conveying pack mentality through synchronised finger snaps, leaps and turns. Indeed, in the song 'Cool', the lyrics "crazy boy//Stay loose, boy" are sung whilst the ensemble is in a jazz split[23]. Masculinity is asserted via dance, considered an 'effeminate' art form. This contradiction emphasises the performativity of gender and sexuality – social norms and stereotypes are simultaneously imposed and proven to be meaningless. This line of argument can be summarised by D.A. Miller's claim that "To perceive the closet was always also to perceive the multitude of conditions under which closeting was possible, to glimpse, even as it was being denied, *the homosexual disposition of the world"*[24]. In summary, the musical's status as performance links it to the closeted queer experience: whilst it lacks LGBTQ+ characters, the musical 'queers' heteronormativity through presenting it as exaggerated and warped.

Thus, according to contemporary understandings of queerness, the musical is a queer entity. While queer meanings are encrypted by heteronormative plots, these are steeped in melodrama and excess to create a 'queering' effect, drawing attention to the 'performance' of being in the closet. Therefore, classic and contemporary musical theatre alike present gender roles and heterosexuality as performative, both onstage and off. For this reason, the musical resonates with an LGBTQ+ audience.

In this conclusion, we come back to the argument trailed at the start of the essay. This time it is more developed and links with the idea of performativity 'onstage and off'.

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[24] D.A. Miller, *Place for Us: Essay on the Broadway Musical* (Cambridge, Mass: Harvard University Press, 1998), p.132-3.

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